

ANALYTICS CONSULTING LAB

SYLLABUS

WINTER 2026

10-16-25 UPDATE

Background on the Analytical Consulting Lab



Analytics Consulting Lab

with
Professor Russell Walker, Ph.D.

UNIVERSITY of WASHINGTON





History and Heritage: **Analytics Consulting Lab (ACL) is an** **Innovative Leader over 18 years Strong!**

Professor Russell Walker Founded the ACL in 2008 :

- Experiential Learning in Action: Analytics + Consulting allows students to learn the business of using Analytics to drive business insights
- Founded in 2008 at the Kellogg School of Management and now homed at the Foster School of Business, over 4700 MBAs and graduate data scientists have taken the course with over 800 unique projects.

MAJOR FOCUS AREAS:

- Analytical Marketing
- Customer Analytics
- Economic Analysis
- Pricing
- Market Entry Analysis
- AI Deployment

MAJOR DOMAINS:

- Sports Management
- Food / Beverage Businesses
- Airlines / Travel
- Sustainability
- Digital / eCommerce
- Healthcare / Insurance
- Financial Services

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The Analytics Consulting Lab (ACL) is part of the Foster experiential learning initiative. The specific interest in the Analytics Consulting Lab comes out of the deep demand for business leaders that can provide guidance in analysis and focus that analysis to specific business questions. Additionally, many recruiters and employers have commented that finding talent that bridges the business and analytical communities is difficult. The ACL strives to provide a real-world learning experience for students to work with sponsoring companies on business questions that revolve around analysis. Students work in teams using analysis (broadly defined) to answer current and important business questions.

Available Projects from the following Leading Firms:

Seattle Mariners – Marketing Promotion Analysis
Microsoft CoPilot AI Opportunities
Amazon Mexico – Payment Analysis
Seattle Seahawks International Expansion
Azul Brazilian Airlines – Expansion and Network Analysis
US Soccer – Marketing or World Cup
Marshall Gerstein IP - Strategies for AI
T-Mobile – AI enabled Search
Paylocity
David Stine Fine Furniture
The Lerner Group – AI investment Opportunities
Taylor Shellfish Farms
Perfect Timing – Business Acquisition
Scale LLP Law Services
Zerone Analytiqs of Africa
Amtrak
Changing Tastes – Diets from Gen Z developed by AI
UW Athletic – Basketball Analysis
José Andrés Group Food Group
Sustainability and Economic Prosperity for Malawi
UW Climate Risk Lab – Impact of Climate Risk on Washington Wines

Project descriptions follow herein.

READ THIS!!!! Course Expectations

Analytics Consulting Lab is an experiential class, with a strong focus on the application of analytics and market measurement in a real-world, client-facing, consulting environment. It provides an excellent opportunity for Foster MBA students to get real-world experience in consulting and in applying analytics and market measurement techniques to actual business challenges and opportunities.

Therefore, it is important to set some very important expectations about this class:

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- **The class does NOT involve lectures to present new theory or analytical techniques. Students seeking new analytical techniques or lectures on analytics, primarily, should consider other courses for that goal. This is a class on the application of analytics in a real-world, team-based environment.**
- **You will work in a team. Team dynamics will be instrumental in your experience.** It is important that you are available, accountable, dedicated, and willing to contribute in a team. In most cases, you get to choose your teammates. Be extremely open and honest with your teammates in terms of their contribution and hold each other accountable in a supportive and respectful manner.
- **The Professor is your advisor, coach, aide, and sounding-board.** He is here to help you in your journey through the project. **The MBA team is in a leadership role to execute the project, communicate and present to the client, and formulate recommendations.**
- The Professor can help you with reviewing regression, analytical concepts, data visualization, consulting best practices, and most any topic that arises on the project. **Execution of the project is, however, the responsibility of the MBA team.**
- **Each project in ACL is unique, real, and driven by an actual client-facing challenge or opportunity.** Your project will vary from others. Projects have different goals, different analytical opportunities, and clearly different clients. You can apply for the project(s) that most interests you.
- **ACL is a lot of work, a lot of learning, and a lot of fun.** Many students consider it a top Foster experience. Be sure that your schedule, life, and other commitments permit you to get the most from the class.

Course Details

The ACL is offered as MKTG 535.

Most projects in the ACL are sponsored by Seattle-based firms, professional contacts of Dr. Walker, and alumni of the school, at very senior levels in their organizations.

Students taking the ACL are assured a strong learning experience and a commitment from the firm to provide access to decision maker and information that will make the experience meaningful.

Application Process

Students interested in the ACL must select MKTG 535 during elective bidding. Once in the class, email Dr. Walker of your:

- Project Choice #1
- Project Choice #2
- Project Choice #3
- Any fellow desired student for a team (limit of one student to specify). Team member preference is only considered if both people select each other.
- Other information that you may wish to share in your application, personal goals, career aspirations, etc.

Student information in the application process is used in formulating teams and assigning projects so that goals, backgrounds, skills, and expectations are all best aligned.

Project Assignment

Student assignments to client projects will be based on individual preferences, requested skill sets and industry experience, and team member diversity. Every attempt will be made to grant students their first or second choice of projects, and only third if necessary. Student information is collected via the application. Students may select one fellow student for a project. This fellow student selection is honored as possible, if the both students select each other.

Students will be notified about their project assignments during the term before the class. All efforts are taken to accommodate first choices, while forming teams with an appropriate set of skills and interests.

Case Packet and Readings

As this course is an experiential one, there are no specific cases to prepare. However, many students have looked for examples of companies that have excelled at Analytics. Also, as the course emphasizes consulting and best practices in a professional client engagement, there is a need to consider some of these best practices. Given this, the following text is recommended and optional:

- 1) The McKinsey Way, Ethan M. Rasiel, McGraw-Hill

These texts are easily purchased on-line, so these are not requested in the bookstore.

Course Meetings

As with other experiential courses, the focus is on the team project and its delivery to the sponsoring company.

Teams will meet with the Professor on a regularly and frequent basis in order to discuss the analysis, flow of work, final presentation and delivery to the sponsoring team. The class will also meet with the prescribed schedule to review concepts and themes important in being successful with the analytical consulting function and in order to provide presentations for the purpose of group learning.

All Group Meetings are to be held with the team and the Professor at a pre-defined time that works mutually. Meetings with the Professor and Client must conclude before 4:30PM on weekdays. Students who cannot make meetings in person are encouraged and welcome to join via telephone.

Pre-term activities

- Project identification
- Team formation
- Identification of Team Liaison to Client
- Identification of Team Liaison to Professor
- Client Introduction
- Project description

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Schedule first group meeting with Professor
Schedule first client meeting with Client

Week I:

Class Session I

Getting Started with ACL
Managing Project Ambiguity
Managing Teams
Overview of the Consulting Approach
Dealing with Data, Descriptive Statistics
Using Tools: JMP, Excel, Tableau

Week II:

Group Meeting I:

Developing a Work Plan, Project Analysis
Examples of Past Analysis
Use of Graphics, Best Practices in Presentation of Data
Building Points Through Analysis

Week III:

Group Meeting II:

Preliminary Analysis of Data
Teams to bring descriptive statistics to meeting with Professor
Work Plans due to Professor

Week IV

Group Meeting III: Focus on Data and Analysis
Address questions and issues in analysis

Week V

Group Meeting IV: Prep for Midpoint Check-in

Class Session II

Mid-term progress review and **team mini-presentations**
Mid-point document due at beginning of class
Mid-point team and mid-point peer feedback due to professor

Week VI :

Group Meeting V:

Mid-point feedback, planning for next phase

Week VII

Group Meeting VI:

As per team needs

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Week VIII

Group Meeting VII:
As per team needs

Week IX

Group Meeting IX:
Dry-run of presentation with Professor

Week X

Class Session III
Project Findings
Final project deliverable due to Professor and Client on last

Wednesday.

Meetings with Clients to be held and presentations made to client in person during or before final week of classes.

As in any professional consulting engagement, the students are requested to regularly meet with the client to receive input, data, direction of project goals, and feedback on the progress as needed. All clients are committed and dedicated to fulfilling the learning and business aspect of the project.

Teams may schedule additional time with the Professor as needed and as available.

Grading

Grading of the project is driven largely by the quality of the team project. The Professor will evaluate the project, its analysis, presentation, and delivery on the following major points:

- Analysis:
 - Quality of analysis (thoroughness, appropriateness)
 - Clarity and quality of model summary and description
 - Intellectual impact (was the analysis creative, novel, clever, or otherwise compelling?)
- Project Document
 - Quality of project description
 - Quality of analysis summary
 - Quality of recommendations and conclusions
 - Use of meaningful graphs, graphs, and presentation of data
- Presentation Documents
 - Quality of presentation
 - Professional impact of the presentation
 - Ability to communicate main points of the analysis and recommendations
- Team Meetings
 - Preparation
 - Organization
 - Progress

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The Professor will ask the client company to provide feedback on the same above points.

Peer evaluations will also be collected from each member. Each student must rate their teammates on the following dimensions:

- Intellectual and creative contribution
- Workload and willingness to take initiative
- Organization, preparation, and availability
- Collaboration and respect for peers

Peer evaluations will be on a 1-10 scale with 10 being excellent and 1 being poor. All peer evaluations will be treated confidentially.

All ACL students must participate, as participation is also important to make this a meaningful learning experience for all involved.

Grade Breakdown

Professor Evaluation of Final project materials and presentation:	40%
Professor Evaluation of Work plan and Mid-point review:	20%
Client Evaluation of Final project materials and presentation:	15%
Peer Evaluations and Participation:	10%
Professor Evaluation of Preparation during meetings:	15%

Role of the Professor

The Professor serves as an aide, counselor, and advisor for the team. The Professor does not conduct the analysis, but will provide detailed direction on analytical approaches. The Professor does not serve as the team liaison or representative to the client. The team must organize itself and identify such a liaison. The Professor may accompany the team to select team meetings and or participate in calls, but the Professor cannot in practically, attend all such meetings.

In the event that the client or the ACL student team encounter an incompatibility or encounter an issue, the Professor will intervene to remedy the situation.

The Professor may also resolve project assignments, as needed.

Role of the Team

The team will consist of 3 to 7 Foster MBA students working as a team to complete analysis, as defined by the client as agreed to before the start of the academic term.

The team should be mindful to control the amount of time that is required of the client. This means being prepared for meetings, having a designated liaison to schedule meetings, request information, and follow-through with next steps. This level of

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preparation and understanding is needed as most clients sponsor this project but do not allocate a full-time associate to work with the ACL team.

The team should expect to contribute about 400-600 hours (depending on team size) over the 10-week period to this ACL project. This is a reasonable expectation for a team working on a project and is consistent with other experiential and lab courses in other MBA programs. This translates to 8-10 hours per person per week.

The team will produce a white paper that documents the study, results, and recommendations. The team will also prepare a presentation and deliver it in person to the client and its team. A reduced version with emphasis on key findings is also to be presented at the last class.

Role of the Client

The client provides the real-world learning opportunity, data needed to complete the appropriate analysis, and feedback on the quality of the project and its analysis. The Client is not expected to solve the problem, but should provide ample expertise, data, and contextual information to the ACL team.

Prerequisites

All students in the ACL must have completed a statistics class. There are no other requirements.

Some FAQs:

What is the Analytical Consulting Lab?

It is a course available to Foster MBA students that are interested in the use of analytics in business. Students must take specific prerequisites and have strong academic performance in such classes to take the Analytics Consulting Lab. Students work in teams to resolve a real-work business problem using analytics.

What do you mean by Analytics?

It is meant to be broad but includes the use of specific quantitative approaches, such as regression analysis, time series analysis, forecasting, market segmentation, data mining, optimization, logistical analysis, scenario simulation, and risk analysis, as examples. In particular, we mean solving a business problem using data and applying one of these quantitative approaches.

How does this experience benefit the students?

Foster MBA students taking the ACL will work on a real-world problem under the direction of Dr. Walker. The opportunity to apply analytical theory and learn about a business, make recommendations, and bring together many aspects of their business education is unparalleled. We also ask that the students focus on how to communicate the

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results of analysis in the context of business decision-making. For students interested in moving to an industry to deep in analytics after graduation or developing new business skills in analytics, this course will be very attractive.

The Analytics field is one of the most demanded in the workforce and students have expressed deep interest in developing strong skills in analytics. This course meets an interest in our students and provides them an exceptional experiential learning opportunity.

How does the Client benefit from this opportunity?

The ACL is an intensive analytics elective that attracts some of our most analytically talented MBA students. It is expected that the student group of 5 will commit about 500 working hours to the project. Additionally, the student project will be overseen by Dr. Walker, who has 20 years plus experience and deep expertise in analytics and its application in business.

We expect that the project deliverables, recommendations, and report will provide direct value to your organization. However, we also believe that the project provides your organization and opportunity to determine how and where to invest in more analytics. If this includes the acquisition of more analytical talent, the project provides an excellent conduit to members of our student body that are talented and interested in this space.

How does the team work with the Client?

For the student team, the partnering company is a client. They will conduct their analysis and provide recommendations through a report and presentation in the same format and in the same manner as a consulting service. The faculty member also serves as an important liaison between the partner and the student, serving to manage time commitments and negotiate deliverables. It is expected that the student team can meet with and speak with key members of your team that can help them answer questions relevant to the analysis.

Which software will we use?

It really depends on the project and your familiarity with software packages. This course is software agnostic, meaning most software packages are acceptable. The course does not have as a goal to teach a particular package, but rather to enable analytics in a business project. You are welcome to use software of your choice. Most projects can well be completed with a combination of Excel and one statistical package. If you are unsure or unfamiliar with statistical software, we will discuss that during our first meeting. Some packages may have a minimal cost.

What about the data?

To make this experience valuable to the students and the to solve the business problem at hand, we do need access to data. It is important that the data be available before the project begins. Additionally, the project should make use of “scrubbed” data, that is data that is free of specific information that would be sensitive or otherwise governed by a law, such as social security numbers of customers or names of customers.

What types of business problems can be considered?

As analytics is helpful in many business functions, we are open to many applications of analytics. Specific business problems in marketing, forecasting, customer segmentation, pricing, commodity analysis, logistics, risk management, operations, inventory leveling, supply chain improvement, and scenario planning are sure to provide great analytical opportunities.

Will the analysis become public?

The work between the students and your organization is considered confidential. If necessary, the students may be asked to sign a non-disclosure agreement. If this is necessary, we ask that the non-disclosure agreement be such that it does not prevent the students from seeking employment or from building on their experience gained on the project.

From time to time, such company-student projects lead to very interesting business lessons. As a leading business school, we are interested in sharing such lessons with our next generation students and business leaders. We do this through business cases. If such an opportunity exists with your project, we will seek your permission to relate the business lesson through a case study.

How to I join the Class?

First, you must meet the prerequisites. Then submit your project selections to Dr. Russell Walker upon entering the course.

Contact Information

Please contact Russell Walker, Ph.D.
Via e-mail: rwalker1@uw.edu

WINTER 2026

ACL

PROJECTS

SEATTLE MARINERS



Marketing Analysis of Promotions

Background: The Seattle Mariners are interested in analyzing our promotion/ giveaway strategy, ensuring it best aligns with intended outcomes of optimizing total revenue earned through tickets, food & beverage sales, merchandise and parking.

Analysis: We would like to understand and have recommendations for the following:

- Most effective types of promotions (collectables, wearables, etc.)
- Best timing for promotions (day of week, seasonality, frequency)
- Marketing messaging and mediums that might better support desired outcomes

The Seattle Mariners are an alumni firm of the ACL!!!

MICROSOFT COPILOT AI OPPORTUNITIES

MICROSOFT.COM



Background

In this contemporary project, students will examine the value of Copilot AI from the lens of businesses. How will businesses use Copilot? What is the use case and value? Associated analysis in value creation and pricing are suggested.

- Create a Business Justification and ROI as a Microsoft Customer to purchase Microsoft Copilot for their business.
- Students must do this based as a small, medium, and enterprise level business. Three business cases.
- Students are expected to research MSFT Copilot and determine:
 - The benefits of Copilot are for the business
 - How and what type of copilot the business will be purchasing.
 - An estimate of cost and time to the business to deploy Copilot.
 - Cost Savings or Revenue Generation or Productivity Opportunities the business will receive.
 - Students will research Microsoft and attempt to bucket what a small, medium, and enterprise business looks like from the Microsoft Perspective.
 - Students may pick any business they like in each of the three customer segmentations.

Microsoft is an alumni firm of ACL!!!

AMAZON MEXICO



Amazon Business Mexico: Market Research Proposal

Payment Methods in Mexico

Amazon Business Mexico operates as a B2B procurement solution designed to serve businesses of all sizes in the Mexican market. Our store combines business-specific value propositions like business discounts, quantity discounts, tax-compliant invoicing, and Data Analytics, complemented by Business Prime benefits and enterprise-level capabilities such as multi-user accounts and approval workflows. The service supports two main customer segments: smaller businesses through a self-service model (SSR) and larger organizations through a customer managed sales approach (CPS). As we navigate challenges such as building market awareness and providing appropriate payment solutions, we continuously evolve our store by implementing new features and improvements that enhance the customer experience and address specific needs of the Mexican business market. Understanding that Mexican businesses utilize diverse payment methods, from digital to cash-based solutions, has become crucial for Amazon Business Mexico's growth and customer experience optimization.

Customer Issues

- Mexican businesses face limitations with current B2B payment options
- Payment method constraints may exclude some potential customers
- Need to validate if cash payment solutions would drive business growth

Objectives

Primary Objectives:

- Map current B2B payment landscape in Mexico
- Identify opportunities to remove friction in payment processes
- Drive customer adoption through optimized payment solutions

Key Questions:

1. What is the current payment mix across different business segments?
2. How do businesses manage cash flow through various payment methods?
3. What barriers prevent digital payment adoption?
4. Would cash payment options (e.g., OXXO) drive incremental sales?

Research Scope

Target Audience:

- SMBs to Enterprise customers
- Focus on high-potential verticals
- Geographic coverage: Major business centers + emerging markets

Payment Methods:

- Digital: Credit/debit cards, SPEI transfers, digital wallets
- Cash-based: Direct deposits, OXXO payments
- Credit solutions: Financing options, installment plans

Success metrics

- Clear understanding of payment preferences by segment
- Actionable insights for product development
- Data-driven recommendations for go-to-market strategy

Deliverables

A comprehensive payment behavior analysis for Businesses in Mexico, based on the size of the businesses.

Amazon and Amazon Mexico are Alumni Firms of ACL!!!

SEATTLE SEAHAWKS



UW Analytics Consulting Lab Project Proposal

Seahawks International Expansion

Project Overview

The Seattle Seahawks are exploring opportunities for international market expansion. As part of the NFL's Global Markets Program, the Seahawks are interested in identifying growth potential, fan engagement strategies, and revenue opportunities in Japan and the Middle East (United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia).

This Analytics Consulting Lab (ACL) project will focus on evaluating these markets through data-driven analysis, providing actionable recommendations to support long-term international growth.

Project Topics

1. Japan
 - Assess the size, demographics, and characteristics of Japan's sports fan base, with emphasis on NFL/football awareness and interest
 - i. Option to also cross-check Washington/Seattle Japanese demographics, trends, sports history, etc.
 - Analyze digital engagement patterns (social media, streaming, merchandise) to identify growth opportunities
 - Recommend marketing, partnership, and fan engagement strategies tailored to Japanese cultural and business contexts
2. Middle East (UAE & Saudi Arabia)
 - Evaluate emerging sports and entertainment in UAE and Saudi Arabia, including government investment, infrastructure, and consumer trends
 - Benchmark the Seahawks against other NFL clubs and international sports teams already active in Middle East
 - Identify potential fan segments and sponsorship opportunities
 - Recommend market-entry strategies that align with local culture, business practices, and growth priorities

The Seahawks are an Alumni firm of the ACL!!!!

AZUL BRAZILIAN AIRLINES



Azul Airlines offers 3 Projects sponsored by the GM of Network and Planning.

Project 1:

On Time Performance for future networks

Project 2:

Optimization and review of operational assumptions, aiming to increase aircraft-time availability to the network

Project 3:

Network actions impact on Customers by customer recognition/scores

About Azul:

Azul Airlines is a Brazilian airline headquartered in São Paulo that operates an extensive domestic network and serves international destinations in the Americas and Europe. Founded by David Neeleman, who also founded JetBlue, Azul started operations in 2008 with the mission to connect Brazil. It is Brazil's largest airline by the number of flights and destinations and is known for its modern fleet and focus on customer service. 



Company background

- **Founder:** David Neeleman, who also founded JetBlue Airways, among other airlines.
- **Founded:** 2008, with operations beginning in December of that year.
- **Headquarters:** São Paulo, Brazil. 

Network and operations

- **Domestic:** Azul is the largest airline in Brazil, offering the most extensive network with up to 900 daily flights to over 150 destinations across the country. 
- **International:** It operates international routes to destinations in South America, the United States, and Europe. 
- **Fleet:** The airline uses a diversified fleet, including ATR, Embraer E-Jets, and Airbus aircraft, to serve various markets. 
- **Hubs:** Key operational hubs are located in Belo Horizonte, São Paulo, and Recife. 

Azul is an alumni Firm of the ACL!!

US SOCCER

USSOCCER.ORG



There is a great opportunity for an analytics research project on a fan engagement/monetization strategy.

The case would be about maximizing revenue on the momentum up through World Cup 2026.

This US Soccer project is led by a Foster ACL alumnus!!!

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About:

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Thesis:

Smaller companies/startups (e.g., entities with less than \$X revenue/year) tend to file patents in emerging technical fields

(e.g., AI). In many cases, the patents of these smaller companies get asserted against larger companies (e.g., Fortune 500 companies) because the smaller companies assert the patents themselves, or the patents of the smaller companies are bought/sold by third parties (e.g., non-practicing entities a/k/a "patent trolls") who assert them.

Question(s):

How many AI-related patents, or patent applications, are currently filed by small companies?

What is the distribution of these patents based on industry.

Which large companies (based on industry) are likely to be targets in the future, and at what percentage based on at least patent count per industry?

This project is sponsored by a proud alumnus of Professor Walker's Class!



The Future of Search in the Age of AI

T-Mobile x UW Analytics Consulting Lab Project Description

Problem Statement

AI-powered search engines and generative platforms are transforming how consumers find and evaluate brands. For T-Mobile, search has traditionally centered on SEO and Paid Search, but the modern search ecosystem now also includes Social Search, Affiliate, and Programmatic channels. As AI reshapes visibility, query flows, and consumer behavior across all five pillars, T-Mobile must understand the risks and opportunities to ensure continued relevance and competitiveness.

Key Business Questions

1. How will AI-powered search engines and generative platforms impact T-Mobile's performance across SEO, Paid Search, Social, Affiliate, and Programmatic?
2. How visible is T-Mobile compared to competitors (i.e. Verizon, AT&T) in generative AI search results?
3. Which types of queries (navigational, transactional, informational) are most vulnerable to AI disruption, and what are the revenue and acquisition implications?
4. How is the consumer journey evolving in an AI-driven search ecosystem, and what new touchpoints or gaps should T-Mobile prioritize?

Analytics & Strategy Challenges

- Model potential shifts in query volumes, click-through rates, and traffic share across all five pillars.
- Build a framework to query AI-driven search platforms and measure share-of-voice.
- Segment queries to identify which intents are most disrupted by AI-generated answers.
- Map the end-to-end user journey today vs in an AI-first landscape, showing where consumers interact with SEO, Paid Search, Social, Affiliate, and Programmatic.
- Quantify downstream impacts on revenue, leads, and brand visibility.

Potential Data Sources

Public / External:

- Google Trends, TikTok/YouTube search data
- AI search engine scraping (telecom-related prompts)
- Competitor content (press releases, product descriptions, social activity)

Internal:

- SEO data (SEMrush, Botify, Nozzle, Google Search Console, Bing Webmaster)
- Paid search campaign data (SA360, Google Ads, Bing Ads)
- Social, Affiliate, and Programmatic performance metrics
- T-Mobile's priority keyword/prompt lists

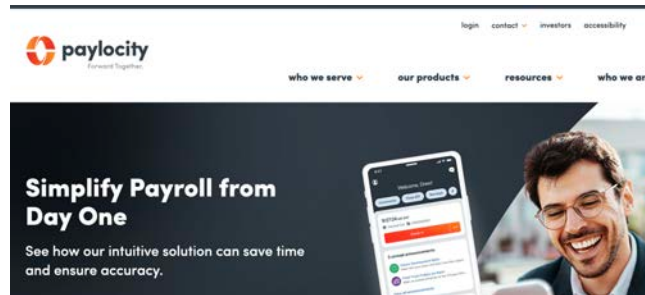
Deliverables

- **Scenario Models:** Forecasted traffic and revenue impacts under multiple AI adoption scenarios (i.e. 10%, 20%, 30% reduction in traditional search-driven traffic).
- **Share-of-Voice Dashboard:** Visibility of T-Mobile vs competitors across AI-driven results.
- **AI-Influenced Journey Maps:** Visual frameworks comparing today's journey with projected AI-first journeys, highlighting disrupted touchpoints and new opportunities.
- **Risk Assessment:** Channel-level analysis of where AI disruption is most impactful.
- **Strategic Recommendations:** Action plan for adapting T-Mobile's SEO, Paid Search, Social, Affiliate, and Programmatic strategies in the age of AI.

T-Mobile is an ACL alumni Firm!!

PAYLOCITY

WWW.PAYLOCITY.COM



Paylocity provides cloud-based HR and payroll software solutions designed to streamline workforce management and enhance employee engagement. This includes products such as:

- Payroll Processing
- Human Capital Management (Recruiting, onboarding, performance management, etc.)
- Time and Attendance
- Benefits Administration
- Employee Self-Service (Access to pay stubs, tax forms, reimbursements, etc.)
- Community
- LMS (Learning Management System)

What You'll Do:

We are looking to create a multi-touch attribution model for Paylocity's Go-To-Market funnel. A comprehensive multi-touch attribution model will help more accurately and independently identify and allocate revenue to the appropriate source(s) of business (i.e., rep generated, channels, digital marketing, client referrals, outbound SDR). Multi-touch attribution will also help Paylocity identify which interactions prompt prospects to continue moving down funnel. This project will impact how Paylocity allocates marketing budget and invests into sales programs and training.

What You'll Gain:

- Hands-on use of cutting-edge marketing analytics tools and methodologies
- A deep understanding of B2B sales funnels and customer acquisition
- Practice turning raw data into real insights and strategy
- Practical experience for future interviews and future roles

Inputs:

- Marketing data: Web Analytics (site visits, content interactions, form fills)
- Sales data: Sales touchpoints (emails, meetings, demos, calls), Salesforce opportunity stages

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- Account level data: Account characteristics and demographics, progression to specific funnel stage, time to funnel stage
- Revenue data: Account level revenue for fiscal year
- Other data sources may be made available if feasible.

Business Questions:

- Attribution and Impact
 - Which marketing and sales touchpoints contribute most to moving prospects down the funnel?
 - How should revenue be allocated across multiple touches when a deal closes?
- Efficiency and Optimization
 - Are there specific sequences or combinations of interactions that are more effective in driving conversions?
 - When do we see diminishing returns?
- Strategic Investment
 - How should budget be reallocated to maximize revenue impact?
 - What channels and programs should be prioritized? What should be scaled back?
- Tactical Implementation
 - What further testing or experimentation could be conducted to validate your findings?
 - What recommendations would you give to marketing and sales leadership to optimize conversion rates and revenue?
 - What other data should we be capturing? Are there gaps in attribution?

Deliverables:

- A document outlining the inputs, outputs, and logic of the attribution model. We expect a mix of quantitative modeling such as regression, ML, or classification models. The document can include code (we prefer python and SQL), model outputs, tree diagrams, etc. We'd expect the following to be addressed:
 - Attribution framework and model
 - Identification of high-impact touchpoints
 - Budget re-allocation recommendation
- A 20 to 30-minute presentation outlining findings to the above business questions. The presentation should be business focused and be oriented towards Sales and Marketing leadership, such as VP of Sales Strategy, Director of Demand Generation, Marketing Manager, Sales Strategy Manager, and Marketing Analyst.

This project is sponsored by a Foster ACL alumnus!

DAVID STINE FURNITURE

STINEWOODWORKING.COM



About Us

We are an award-winning company specializing in natural wood furniture handcrafted from sustainably harvested American hardwoods. Our work is offered to the trade and to the public. The work is high end; our average price point is \$3,500. We've been in business 27 years and we have four full-time employees.

Strengths

We are vertically integrated: We own the land where we harvest the wood; the sawmills where we mill the wood; the kilns where we dry the wood; the seasoning and storage sheds where we store the wood; the wood shops, showroom, vehicles, and equipment. We have no debt.

We stay in our lane and play to our strengths: Large flat surfaces – dining and conference tables, desks, coffee tables, benches, etc. We do not offer cabinetry or small items (like boxes).

We have a devoted 45,000-person following on Instagram and our SEO is fairly robust.

We have a strong foothold in the STL area and have developed a dedicated commercial/trade clientele.

Weaknesses

We have a very limited budget for advertising and marketing.

We no longer exhibit in trade shows. We rely exclusively on high-touch marketing, at which we excel; social media; web site traffic; outreach to current and new clients; and exposure via our commercial and hospitality work.

Despite boosting posts and following algorithms, our Instagram feed is not growing nearly as much as our competitors, who have hundreds of thousands of followers while we have just 45,000.

Problem Statement

We seek to better understand the landscape of social media and marketing for a small company like ours; specifically, how we can leverage our unique and authentic brand and story across platforms.

We seek to better understand how people now shop for high-end custom furniture and how we can capture that.

We seek to better understand Google Analytics, our customer buyer data, and our social media outreach so that we can market our work more effectively.

What are the sales and marketing opportunities we are missing?

We envision the students helping us wade through the data to better understand how our marketing efforts are — or are not — paying off. We also envision the students helping us to develop data on our buyers so that we may market more effectively. As resources and expertise are limited, we are interested in creative ways to utilize this information in cost-effective ways.

David Stine is an ACL Alumni Firm!!

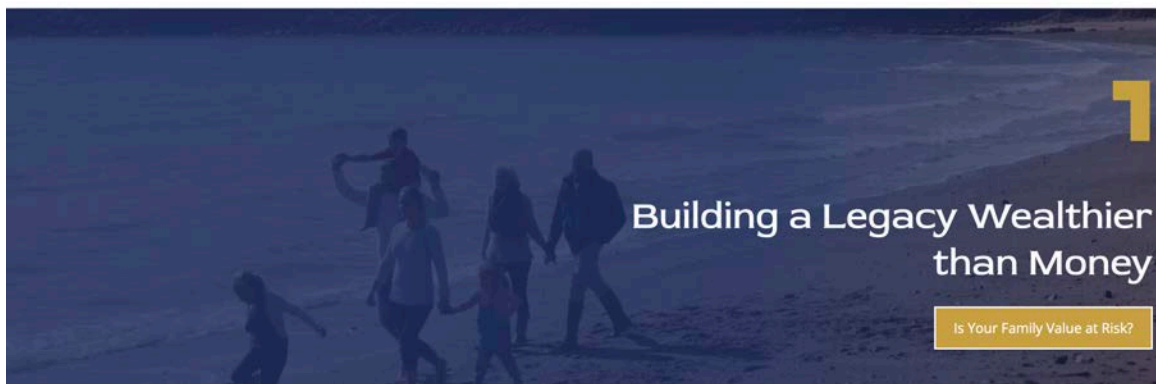
THE LERNER GROUP

AI INVESTMENT OPPORTUNITIES

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Lerner is looking for a team to do analysis on the investment landscape and the impact of AI on various industries. To that end it would be great if teams can do research to provide insight on the following –

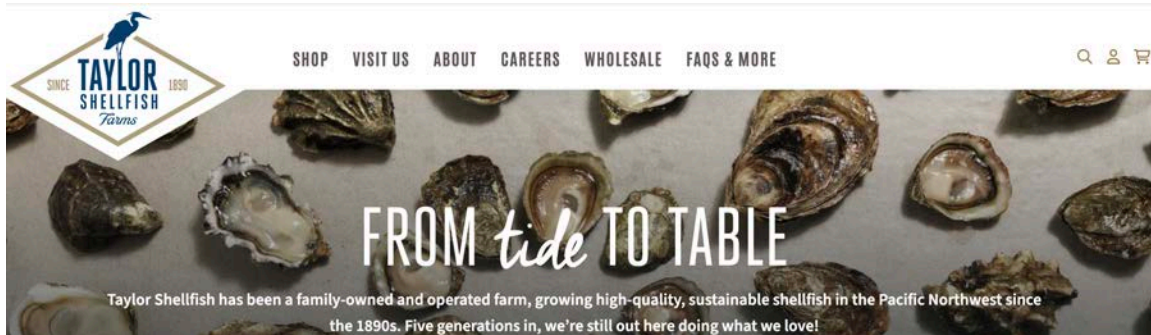
- Conduct a comprehensive analysis of the current artificial intelligence (AI) industry, focusing on the investment landscape, supply chain dynamics, and the companies best positioned to benefit from AI's rapid adoption. It will assess the overall market size and growth trajectory, identify key trends such as the rise of generative and spatial AI, increasing demand for AI infrastructure, and the integration of AI into global supply chains for efficiency and resilience.
- The study will map the AI value chain—from critical inputs like advanced semiconductors (e.g., NVIDIA, AMD, TSMC – public) and chip design software (e.g., Synopsys – public) to cloud infrastructure providers (e.g., Microsoft Azure, AWS – public) and enabling hardware firms (e.g., Lambda, Crusoe – private).

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- It will also profile application-layer innovators across sectors, including public companies such as SoundHound AI and private leaders like OpenAI, Anthropic, Scale AI, and Databricks, evaluating their market positioning, funding, and growth potential.
- By distinguishing between public and private players, the project will highlight where capital is flowing, which segments of the supply chain and technology stack are poised for outsized returns, and which industries—such as healthcare, manufacturing, logistic and retail—stand to gain the most from AI-driven transformation.

The Lerner Group is a proud ACL alumni Firm!!!

TAYLOR SHELLFISH FARMS



Project 1: Tinned Seafood Market Evaluation

Taylor Shellfish Farms, through its Ekone brand, produces premium smoked oysters and other specialty tinned seafood. As demand for shelf-stable proteins grows, we are seeking a comprehensive market evaluation to guide a long-term marketing strategy for this category.

The project will focus on developing a full demographic and market study for the U.S. and select international markets. Students will analyze:

- Market Size & Growth Potential – Current size of the tinned seafood category, projected growth rates, and major regional variations.
- Consumer Demographics – Age, gender, income levels, education, and lifestyle attributes of core and emerging consumer segments.
- Regional & Channel Focus – Where demand is strongest (e.g., coastal vs. inland markets, urban vs. rural) and which retail and online channels show the greatest opportunity.
- Behavioral Insights – Consumer motivations, purchasing frequency, price sensitivity, and attitudes toward sustainability and health.
- Competitive Landscape – Review of leading brands and product positioning, with an emphasis on premium and specialty segments.

Project 2: Live Oyster Market Landscape & Growth Strategy

Objective. Build a rigorous, data-driven view of the live (in-shell) oyster market to inform Taylor Shellfish Farms' growth strategy across regions and channels.

Key Questions.

- U.S. market size & structure: What is the current domestic market size (units & \$), and how many oysters are sold annually? Break down by species (Pacific, Eastern, Kumamoto, European), cultivation method (aquaculture

- vs. wild), grade/size (half-shell vs. shucking), and format (farm-direct, wholesale, foodservice, retail seafood counters).
- Where are they sold? Map sales by region and channel (restaurants/raw bars, grocery/seafood counters, distributors, online). Identify the markets moving the greatest volume and highest value (e.g., Northeast corridor, West Coast metros, destination raw-bar cities).
 - Supply origins & seasonality: Where do U.S. live oysters come from (state/estuary, hatchery seed pathways), and how do seasons, closures, and regulations shift supply? Assess import/export flows that touch the live market.
 - Trends & demand drivers: Dining trends (raw-bar expansion, premiumization), sustainability certifications, health/fitness messaging, experiential dining, tourism, price elasticity, and biosecurity/regulatory impacts (e.g., Vibrio, norovirus controls).
 - Global outlook: What is the global live oyster market size (\$/units)? Which countries are the largest producers/consumers, and what cuisines and occasions lead consumption? Who is eating oysters (demographics/psychographics), and what are the future markets (emerging cities, tourism hubs, higher-income segments, e-commerce)?

Approach & Data Sources.

- Secondary research: NOAA/USDA/ERS, FAO FishStat, UN Comtrade, state grower associations, Technomic/Datassential (foodservice), Nielsen/IRI (retail seafood counters where available), industry reports, academic literature.
- Primary insights: Interviews with distributors, raw-bar buyers, chefs, and seafood category managers in priority metros; internal Taylor sales by SKU/region to triangulate sizing.
- Analytics: Size the market top-down and bottom-up; create a regional heat map; channel mix model; seasonality index; scenario forecast (base/optimistic/constrained).

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FIND WORK



FIND TALENT

Business Owner Acquires a Company and Looks to Grow

This project will help a recently acquired staffing and recruiting company doing several million dollars in revenue. The owner is looking to invest and grow the business, but needs to better understand the business first.

The project might answer: What is the average customer lifetime value? Who are the most profitable clients? What is our gross margin? What is the gross margin by client? How should we price and package our candidates? What markets should we pursue?

This is an opportunity to get actual hands-on data from a small business and to help the owners answer key questions. As this is exploratory, we are open to a student team's creative ideas for what factors to examine.

SCALE LLP LAW SERVICES



SCALE LLP

Founded by former tech GCs and business leaders, Scale is a fully distributed, tech-enabled, business-forward law firm built to deliver experienced counsel without the inefficiencies and overhead of traditional models. For clients, that means access to seasoned attorneys across corporate, IP, litigation, regulatory, real estate, and general counsel functions — backed by agility, transparency, and strategic insight. Whether you're a fast-growing startup needing trusted counsel or an established business navigating complexity, Scale delivers the agility and depth of counsel that empower companies to grow, adapt, and lead in evolving markets.

Background

The legal industry has been relying on the billable hour model for decades. Pursuant to this model, lawyers charge fees for legal services based strictly on the time the lawyers working on any given legal project spend completing the project. Time is recorded in tenths of an hour (time is tracked in six-minute increments), and bills describe, in exacting detail, what the lawyer spent his or her time doing on that matter during that time. Of course, pursuant to this model, payment of legal services is completely divorced from the success of those services or their value to the client. Effectively, legal services are priced using a “cost plus” model.

Project & Deliverables

Scale LLP would like your help rethinking this model. Rather than the “cost plus” model followed by the rest of the industry, Scale LLP would like to follow a “demand based” pricing model as closely as possible. We would like your help figuring out how best to price matters.

Specifically, we need your help with the following:

- First, Scale LLP maintains approximately a decade's worth of billing data, which is well organized and divided into different types of legal matters such as corporate matters, litigation matters, IP matters, and general legal advice. We would like you to analyze this billing data to help us understand how much prior matters of different kinds have cost, both in terms of attorney time and in terms of actual cost.
- Second, we would like you to make recommendations for future pricing models with clients. There are a number of current alternative fee arrangement models in

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existence, such as options like fixed fees, success premiums, contingency fees, rate and budget caps, and hybrid models (e.g., where hourly rates can change based on conditions of the matter). However, unfortunately, none of these are widely used. We would like a rubric for when these (and other) pricing models would be most profitable and what prices to recommend. In other words, we'd like you to help us identify not only our costs of representation (point 1) but also how much clients value the representation. During this part of the project, please keep in mind that the legal landscape is rapidly changing – tools like Harvey, Co-Counsel, Crosby and other AI platforms may significantly reduce the amount of lawyer's time necessary to complete any given task.

- Third, as you assess our historical data, we expect there will be other useful insights that come out. Please share those. Things that we are interested in include information about collections, such as what types of matters and clients see better collections and what matters and clients see worse collections or non-payment; what our staffing mixes are on particular matters, and how that impacts revenue, profitability, and collection; and the profitability and revenue of different matter (and sub-matter) types.

Ultimately, we'd like a PowerPoint presentation discussing a new pricing model, which will include a robust analysis of our historical data, address the impact of AI-generated legal service platforms, and include other actionable insights based on our data. We look forward to working with you disrupting the status quo for pricing legal services.

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UW Foster ACL Projects	
Company Name	Zerone Analytiqs
Company Background	Zerone Analytiqs is a data analytics company with a mission to empower decision-making with data and analytics. We aim to fuel Africa's development with the possibilities of data and envision being the trusted partner in providing analytics and intelligent solutions to corporations, non-profits and governments across the African continent. By helping organizations optimize their risk-based decisions and enabling consumers to understand and manage their personal information, Zerone seeks to empower organizations with the provision of in-depth analysis and insights particularly on Africa. When individuals, researchers, educators, corporations and governments have access to more complete and multidimensional data, they can make better informed decisions, create innovations, reach new frontiers and reduce their risk. Zerone Analytiqs is a startup company incorporated in Ghana in 2022. Our primary focus is on Africa. We have two projects available for MBA students to work on. Students may choose to work on any one of the two projects.
Project 1: Banking Industry Analysis and Strategy	
Project Focus Area(s)	Data Analysis, Customer Profiling, Strategy Development, Business Development
Scope of work	Zerone Analytiqs has collected customer interests, preferences, and feedback on banking experiences in Ghana through its new mobile application, ZeroneData. The company seeks an MBA team to analyze the data and provide actionable insights to help banks in Ghana optimize customer acquisition and retention strategies. The key focus of this project is to develop customer personas, assess marketing strategies for financial institutions, identify gaps in the banking industry, and recommend market entry strategies for North American banks interested in entering the Ghanaian market. We would like the MBA students in UW's Foster ACL to analyze relevant user data points and determine the following: 1. Create suitable personas/profiles for different categories of customers you identify from the data. 2. What marketing techniques/channels will be best situated for bank/financial institutions who are seeking to grow their customers based on the different customer profiles you identified about. 3. What market gaps can you identify in the Ghanaian Banking Industry based on responses and other publicly available research/data. 4. Based on gaps in the market (as revealed by survey responses), suggest 2-3 entry strategy that a prospective North American (US & CA) bank seeking to enter this market can adopt to be successful. key initiatives that Zerone can propose to any 3 of the top 10 banks in Ghana to help capture more value from new and existing customers.
Deliverables	1. A Comprehensive report detailing customer personas, strategic marketing recommendations for Ghanaian financial institutions, market gap analysis and opportunity identification and entry strategy for North American banks with actionable recommendations. 2. Presentation to the co-founders summarizing analysis, findings and recommendations

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Project 2: Beverage Industry Market Insight and Strategy

Project Focus Area(s)	Market Research, Data Analysis, Consumer Behavior Analysis, Data Visualization, Strategy Development
Scope of work	Zerone Analytiqs, using its new mobile application – ZeroneData – has gathered data on customers preference, consumption frequencies and feedback from consuming beverages in Ghana. The company seeks MBA students to analyze this data and produce a market insight article that helps beverage companies understand customer behavior and develop successful strategies. This project will focus on identifying beverage preferences, analyzing industry leaders, and predicting future trends. Additionally, the team will recommend entry strategies for new players in the beverage market, including North American brands looking to expand into Ghana. We would like the MBA students in UW's Foster ACL to analyze relevant user data points and write a market insight article (with data visualizations) that addresses the following questions: 1. What type of customers prefer which types of beverages? 2. What are the best performing beverage companies doing differently? What channel are the most successful? 3. As a potential new entrant into the beverage market – what entry strategy will be best 4. Predict the direction of future customer preferences (pricing, product, appeal, channels, etc) and how beverage companies should position themselves for success? 5. Considering Ghanaian beverage consumers' behavior/preferences determine a top 2-3 North American (US & CA) beverage brands that could successfully enter and operate in this industry. What characteristics are uniquely common to the consumers of these north American beverages and the Ghanaian beverage consumer.
Deliverables	1. A comprehensive market insight report on the beverage industry in Ghana with data visualizations and customer segmentation analysis, strategic recommendations for beverage companies to stay competitive and innovative and strategies for top 2-3 North American beverage brands that could enter the Ghanaian beverage industry. Include predictions on future trends and consumer behavior in the beverage industry. 2. Presentation to the co-founders summarizing analysis, findings and recommendations.

AMTRAK



UW-Amtrak Project Description:

Effect of Increased Mobile and Loyalty Program Engagement on Customer Behavior

Project Overview:

The Market Research and Customer Analytics teams at Amtrak are wishing to collaborate with students in the UW Foster Analytics Consulting Lab to explore how joining Amtrak's Guest Rewards Loyalty program and downloading Amtrak's mobile app impacts frequency of travel and spend per customer. By analyzing travel history and behavioral patterns of similar customers before and after joining AGR or downloading the app, the project aims to uncover whether such actions lead to increased usage and deeper customer loyalty across different segments.

This project will provide students with an opportunity to dive deep into customer data, work with cross-functional teams, and uncover real world insights while exercising their analytical skills. Students will have access to anonymized customer data and survey results to conduct a comprehensive analysis.

Objectives:

Data Analysis: Students will analyze various fields from Amtrak's customer database, including, but not limited to:

- Travel frequency and spend
 - Station pairs and trip types
 - AGR membership status and tenure
 - Mobile app usage
 - Demographic information
 - Booking channels and trip lead time
- All data will be scrubbed of customer PII.*

Customer Segmentation & Modeling:

Students will segment customers based on similar travel patterns prior to joining AGR or downloading the app. Using techniques such as clustering and propensity score matching, they will compare post-engagement behavior between matched groups (AGR members vs. non-members, app users vs. non-users) to assess the impact of digital engagement and loyalty status.

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Survey Analysis: Students will incorporate findings from Amtrak's standing AGR survey to enrich their analysis. This survey includes insights into member satisfaction, sought after values in loyalty programs, etc. Students may identify which program features or satisfaction drivers correlate with increased travel or spend.

Work Product:

Students will deliver a comprehensive report and presentation that includes:

- Key differences between app and non-app users
- Key differences between loyalty members and non-members
- Identification of customer segments most likely to benefit from digital engagement and Amtrak's Loyalty Program
- Recommendations for Amtrak based off findings

Amtrak is an Alumni firm of the ACL!!!

CHANGING TASTES

FOOD, AND ENVIRONMENT ECONOMICS



Changing Tastes is a strategy, culinary, and sustainability consultancy creating successful ventures and meaningful change in the food sector.

We work with our clients to achieve greater success by understanding and finding opportunities at the intersection of five key trends that are driving change in our food system: sustainability, public health, information technology, demographics, and the changing role of the culinary professional and foodservice industry.

Project 1: What Should We Grow?

How can AI advise food companies and farmers on what to plant and harvest in a couple years period that's the amount of time it takes from the seed of an idea, to finding the right land planting seeds and harvesting new crops or expanding production of existing foods.

There's a lot of siloed data in different parts of government and several different industries, including consumer foods and agriculture, that must be brought together and analyzed and modeled over time, far beyond the capabilities of the “data poor” food industry. These include trends in what flavors and types of food people want, parsing this

by generation, forecasting changing demographics in the US by age and ethnicity including immigration and exploration that bring new flavors on an ever more rapid basis, examining how tastes change as people age and move from college student to living on their own to families with kids over the several years from “now” to “then”, the impact of climate change on the viability of crops in different parts of the world, and long term changes in commodity prices that signal what is the most profitable thing to plant.

Project 2: Understanding Price Signals

The classic commodity challenge is misreading short term increases in price as long term increases in demand, and by the time new production is on there's a glut and prices go down. When this happens in the agriculture industry, the environmental damage can be extensive. Brazil clears swaths of the Amazon to grow soybeans next year in response to a flood in America's heartland, only to find there's no demand for the new soybeans once they're harvested.

Other times the demand is real and long term, from the shift in American appetites from beef to chicken and a very different mix of grains for feed, to the growing interest in more peas beans and other pulses for plant based foods, or our seemingly insatiable infatuation with avocados.

This project would look to see if there are any discernible market signals or mix of pricing and other news that can help decision makers make choices that are demand based, rather than clear new land and forests in response to luck events that do not reflect a change in demand but rather a short term change in supply. The results could provide substantial benefit for business and our planet.

Changing Tastes in an Alumni firm of the ACL!!!

UW ATHLETICS – ANALYSIS



Project Research Question

As basketball performance varies significantly game-to-game, with players showing different levels of dependability despite similar ability levels, the existing ON score captures player capability but not their consistency or predictability. It's advantageous to develop a different measure to complement the ON score that reflects how consistently players meet performance expectations. This measure would enable coaches and administrators to make more informed roster management decisions, including player compensation determinations and strategic choices about bench depth and transfer portal additions. This measure is particularly valuable when limited data creates uncertainty about new players. By quantifying whether players consistently deliver on their expected performance levels, the Consistency Score (CS) will provide critical insights that complement the established ON score's ability measurements.

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The students are expected to (1) review and consider the findings from the previous project, building upon the hierarchical framework presented in the Spring 2025 project to (2) create a CS that measures game-to-game variability, performance stability under different conditions, and dependability trends over time, then (3) integrate measures created from the Spring 2025 project and the CS score (ON score for ability, CS for reliability) to create a comprehensive Team Strength Index.

The students will use public college basketball player performance data, leveraging the same hierarchical structure and statistical approaches established in the ON score paper. The developed Consistency Score and integrated Team Strength Index will be used by the AD and UW Basketball Coaches to evaluate roster stability, assess the risk-reward tradeoffs of potential transfers, and optimize lineup combinations for performance.

UW Athletics is an alumni partner of the ACL!!! GO DAWGS!!!

JOSÉ ANDRÉS GROUP— PAELLA FOR AMERICANS – US MARKET ANALYSIS



CUSTOMER TASTES AND MARKET DEVELOPMENT

A Market Study of the US for a Paella Kit for Americans

Paella is a festive dish, often considered the quintessential dish of Spain and even thought of as the national dish of Spain. Americans enjoy a very international diet, with homemade pizza and tacos being common meals. Each offer a warm, tasty, economical, and ethnic cuisine. Paella, and Spanish cuisine, has not enjoyed the adoption of tacos and pizza. This begs the question, can a paella kit be developed and marketed to meet the US consumer needs? There are pizza and taco kits, for instance.

In this market analysis, the team will be expected to analyze:

1. The US market for Paella demand, with growth projections
2. Obstacles and hurdles to paella adoption
3. Solutions to the obstacles and hurdles
4. Marketing ideas, inclusive of social media positioning
5. The 4Ps: Price, Placement, Product, Promotion

ACL is proud to partner with the José Andrés Group on this project!!!

TUBEPOKA DEVELOPMENT INITIATIVE – MALAWI STUDY

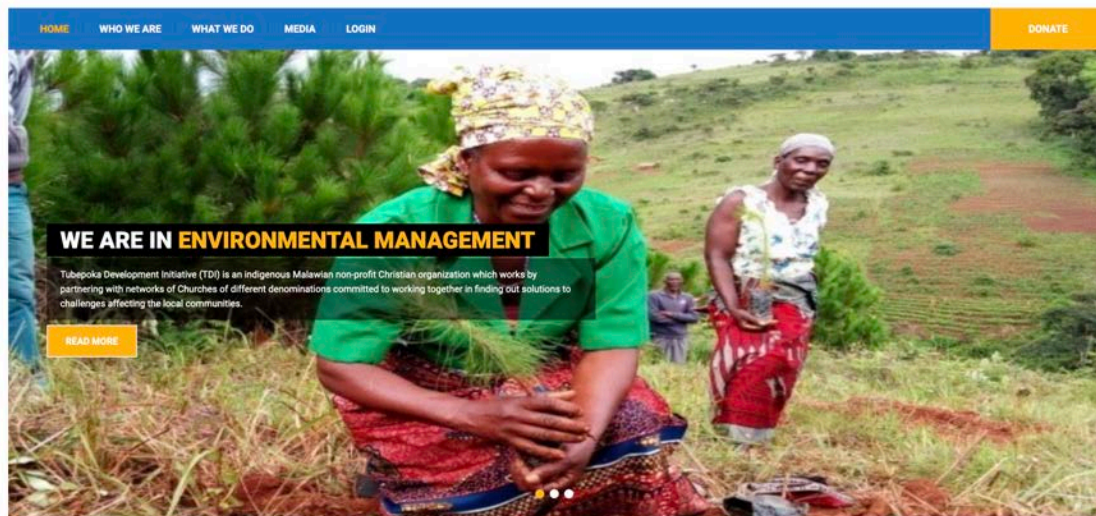
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ABOUT US

Tubepoka Development Initiative (TDI) is an indigenous Malawian non-profit Christian organization which works by partnering with networks of Churches of different denominations committed to working together in finding out solutions to challenges affecting the local communities.

In an effort to develop Malawi in a manner to bring prosperity to its people, the Tubepoka Development Initiative (TDI) proposes a research project on the development of a comprehensive business plan for the feasibility of entering the banana industry and provide strategic recommendations for successful market entry and growth.

As you may be aware, the global demand for bananas has continued to rise owing to population growth in the region and elsewhere, making it a lucrative and

promising market. However, the banana industry is highly competitive, and developing a robust business plan is critical for long-term sustainability and profitability. The objective of this research project is to provide the necessary analysis and insights to guide TDI's decision-making process in entering the banana market.

The proposed research will consist of the following key components:

1. **Market Analysis:** This will include an in-depth examination of the current banana market in Malawi, including global and regional demand, key competitors, pricing trends, customer preferences, and potential barriers to entry. By understanding the market dynamics, TDI can identify its unique value proposition and target customer segments.
2. **Supply Chain Assessment:** The research will assess the banana supply chain, from sourcing and production to distribution and retailing. Understanding the supply chain's efficiency, potential risks, and cost structures will enable TDI to develop a competitive advantage and ensure smooth operations.
3. **Financial Analysis:** A comprehensive financial analysis will be conducted, evaluating the investment required for setting up banana plantations, processing facilities, transportation, marketing, and overhead expenses. This analysis will also forecast revenue streams, profitability, and potential return on investment for TDI.
4. **Sustainability Practices:** Given the increasing importance of sustainability in consumer decisions, the research will explore best practices in sustainable banana farming and production. This consideration will enable TDI to align with environmental and social responsibility standards, enhancing brand reputation and customer trust.
5. **Risk Analysis:** The research will identify and assess potential risks and challenges, such as climate change, disease outbreaks, fluctuating market prices, and regulatory constraints. This risk analysis will allow TDI to develop effective risk management strategies and contingency plans.
6. **Strategic Recommendations:** Based on the findings from the above analyses, the research will provide strategic recommendations for TDI to successfully enter the banana market, including market positioning, target markets, marketing strategies, and growth opportunities.

The proposed timeline for this research project is approximately 10 weeks, with regular updates and progress reports. TDI kindly seek your contribution and support for the initiation of this research project and further believe that conducting thorough research with UW Foster ACL will serve as a foundation for

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the successful development and implementation of a banana business plan for Tubepoka Development Initiative (TDI) and will advance the lives and prosperity of the people of Malawi.

ACL is proud to support this project and one of the TDI thought leaders is an ACL alumnus!!

UW FOSTER CLIMATE RISK LAB

Capstone Project:

Translating Rising Heat into Financial Risk & Opportunity for Washington State Wine Producers

Introduction

Washington's wine industry faces rapid warming, more frequent heat spikes, and shifting phenology—creating both risks (yield loss, quality downgrades, higher cooling/irrigation costs) and opportunities (new sites/varietals, longer seasons, premium positioning).

This 10-week, consulting-style capstone engages MSBA students to quantify how rising heat affects vineyard and winery economics across Washington American Viticultural Areas (AVAs), and to surface ROI-positive adaptation strategies. The final deliverable will be a Tableau data story designed for decision-makers at participating wineries and regional stakeholders.

Students will meet weekly with to-be-determined representatives from at least one small and one large WA producer to ground analysis in real operational realities and commercial goals. The [UW Climate Risk Lab](#) will provide guidance and data access.

Scope & Research Questions

The team will evaluate heat-driven financial impacts and opportunities for WA vineyards/wineries, with emphasis on translating climate signals into P&L effects and investment decisions.

Key Research Questions:

- How have growing degree days (GDD), extreme-heat days (e.g., $\geq 35^{\circ}\text{C}/95^{\circ}\text{F}$) and warm nights trended across key WA AVAs, and how do they correlate with yield, quality metrics, and realized grape/wine prices?
- What are the cost drivers of heat management (e.g., irrigation, shade cloth, canopy labor, misting, refrigeration/fermentation cooling energy), and how do they impact gross margin?
- Where do site and varietal shifts (e.g., altitude/aspect/northern AVAs; heat-tolerant cultivars) create positive NPV opportunities under moderate and high-heat scenarios?

- What operational playbooks (harvest timing/night harvest, canopy & trellis strategy, cold chain upgrades, contract adjustments) yield the best risk-adjusted ROI?
- How can producers communicate “resilience premium” attributes (quality stability, sustainable water use) to strengthen brand and pricing power?

Data Sources & Analytical Approach

CRL-Provided / Priority Data

- Historical & projected heat: downscaled CMIP6 ensembles (selected scenarios).
- Geospatial: WA AVA boundaries; vineyard/site polygons (where available); terrain (elevation, slope, aspect).
- Operations & finance (anonymized where needed and TBC): Yield/quality records, irrigation volumes, energy bills, labor logs, capex/opex for heat adaptations, grape contracts and realized case/gross-to-net.

Supplemental / Suggested

- USDA NASS crop/yield & price series; WA State Wine Commission reports; utility tariffs (cooling/fermentation energy cost benchmarking); water rights/allocations (public datasets).
- Optional market/retail signals to triangulate premium positioning.

Analytical Design

Students will choose one or more frameworks and implement them in Tableau with reproducible notebooks as needed:

- Heat–Yield–Price Elasticity: Link AVA-level heat indices (GDD, heat spikes, warm nights) to yield, Brix/TA proxies, grape price per ton, and case pricing; estimate revenue-at-risk and margin sensitivity.
- Operations Cost Curve: Model incremental cooling energy, irrigation, labor vs. heat intensity; build unit-economics waterfall from vine to bottle.
- Adaptation ROI / NPV: Compare capex/opex (shade cloth, variable-rate irrigation, misting, glycol/chiller upgrades, insulation, micro-site planting) vs. avoided loss and price stability; present payback & IRR.
- Varietal & Site Optimization: Scenario-test cultivar mixes and micro-site moves (altitude/aspect/northern AVAs); visualize opportunity maps.

- Commercial Strategy Lens: Identify brand/resilience premiums and procurement/contract clauses (heat clauses, quality bands) that stabilize cash flows.

Students will prioritize scenario analysis over long-range deterministic forecasting, and will document assumptions, uncertainty ranges, and data lineage in an appendix.

Project Milestones & Timeline (10 Weeks)

Week 1–2: Kickoff & Discovery

- Stakeholder interviews (small & large producer reps); confirm KPIs (yield, quality, \$/ton, \$/case, margin).
- Ingest climate/operations data; define AVA focus set; draft data dictionary & ethics plan.

Week 3–4: EDA & Framework Selection

- Build Tableau heat indicators (GDD trends, $\geq 95^{\circ}\text{F}$ days, warm nights, spatial gradients).
- Correlate heat with yield/price; lock the primary scenario framework(s); agree on 2–3 producer-relevant decision questions.

Week 5–6: Deep-Dive Analysis

- Construct financial sensitivity models (revenue-at-risk, cost curves).
- Run Adaptation ROI and Varietal/Siting scenarios; iterate with producers in weekly working sessions.

Week 7–8: Prototype → Story

- Ship Tableau Data Story v1 (narrative, KPI dashboards, comparison views, map layers).
- User-test with both producers; incorporate feedback; finalize assumptions/footnotes.

Week 9: Executive Packaging

- Convert insights into actionable playbooks (no-regrets, near-term, strategic bets).
- Prepare the executive brief and presenter notes aligned to producer outcomes.

Week 10: Final Delivery & Review

- Live presentation to participating wineries and the UW Climate Risk Lab; handoff of Tableau workbook and documentation.

Final Deliverable

A **Tableau-based data story** plus a concise executive presentation that provides:

- AVA-level and site-level heat exposure metrics and trend visualizations.
- Revenue-at-risk & margin sensitivity under two heat scenarios (moderate / high).
- Adaptation ROI pack (ranked by payback/IRR, capex/opex, water/energy implications).
- Opportunity maps for varietal/siting shifts and premium positioning.
- A Producer Playbook: 10–12 specific actions with estimated \$ impact and complexity.

Student Experience & Engagement

- Weekly producer touchpoints (one small, one large) to validate assumptions and iterate prototypes.
- Optional field visit or virtual facility walk-through (fermentation/cold room/irrigation systems).
- Mini-methods clinics with CRL (heat metrics, uncertainty, causal caveats, financial translation).
- Eligibility for an affiliated LinkedIn credential from the UW Climate Risk Lab upon successful completion.

Project Sponsors & Partners

UW Climate Risk Lab – Climate analytics, financial modeling guidance, and data access.

WA Wine Producer Partners (TBD) – Weekly engagement; operations and commercial context; validation.

(Optional) FactSet / market data access – For triangulating price and margin implications.

Client Contact: Professor Phillip Bruner, Executive Director, UW Climate Risk Lab

<https://foster.uw.edu/uw-climate-risk-lab/>